



Shaheed Bhagat Singh Evening College

(University of Delhi)

Assessed and Accredited by NAAC with GRADE 'A' {CGPA 3.36}



Project Report
of
Innovation Project

Titled

**Socio-Cultural Assimilation: Integrating
Multiculturalism and Multilingualism in English
Classes at College Level**

Project Code: RICGP/00/SBSE/2021

Under

Prof. Chhavi Sharma
(Principal Investigator)

And

Savita Kiran
(Co-Investigator)

Prof Poonam Chaudhary
(Co-Investigator)



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CERTIFICATE

It gives me immense pleasure to certify that **Prof. Chhavi Sharma**, **Principal Investigator** of the project titled “Socio-Cultural Assimilation: Integrating Multiculturalism and Multilingualism in English Classes at College Level” (Project Code: RICGP/0021/SBSE/2021), **Co-PIs, Savita Kiran and Prof Poonam Chaudhary** have successfully submitted their project. They have met the required parameters. I congratulate Prof. Chhavi Sharma, her team and student interns for a commendable work.

I wish them all success.

(Prof. Chandra Shekhar Dubey)

Project Coordinator

IQAC, Coordinator

SBSEC, University of Delhi.

Date:



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CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that the work reported in the project entitled **Socio-Cultural Assimilation: Integrating Multiculturalism and Multilingualism in English Classes at College Level** Submitted by **Prof Chhavi Sharma (Principal Investigator), Savita Kiran (Co-Principal Investigator) and Prof Poonam Chaudhary (Co-Principal Investigator)** has been carried out under my mentorship.

The data reported in Research Project is genuine. It represents their original work and the project is worthy of consideration for submission.

(Prof Saroj K Mahananda)
Department of English
Jamia Milia Islamia, Delhi

Date:

Acknowledgement

First and foremost, we wholeheartedly thank Prof. Sudhir Kumar Sinha, Principal, Shaheed Bhagat Singh Evening College, and Prof. Chandrashekhar Dubey, Convenor, IQAC of the college, who were instrumental in approving this project. We also owe our sincere thanks to Prof Saroj K Mahananda for mentoring this project. We are also thankful to the student researchers involved in this project who worked hard throughout the course of research for data collection, analysis and presentation. We are also grateful to the respondents both students and teachers who took time from their schedule and shared the required details. We are thankful to the students who were the part of the experiment and contributed in the successful completion of this project.

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ABSTRACT

India is a land of cultural diversity and linguistic plurality. This diversity is represented – and informed – by various cultural components such as castes, faiths, food habits, languages and other multiple determinants. Among all these cultural traits, language is arguably the most important apparatus of cultural identity as it is the medium through which a group of people identify and communicate with one another and perceive the world. Thus, it is imperative to promote multilingualism and multiculturalism at every level of teaching.

The main aim of the project is to explore ways to include lived experiences of the students in the classroom and suggest ways for making English Language Teaching (ELT) in Higher Education more engaging and culturally grounded. The project attempted to achieve this aim by engaging teachers and students on the course content, delivery and other related issues and revisit the same through alternative culturally located ‘texts’ and quantitatively and qualitatively evaluate the differences in students’ understanding of these issues. This line of investigation is intended to arrive at a new baseline standard that can then be implemented across the board to other literature classrooms across the country.

Key-Words: English Language Teaching (ELT), Decolonization, Contextualisation and Localization, Multiculturalism

1. INTRODUCTION

Linguistic plurality and Cultural diversity are at the core of the idea of India. This diversity is represented by variation in culture components such as languages, religions, castes, food habits and multiple other determinants. Among all these cultural traits, language is arguably the most important apparatus of cultural identity as it is the medium through which a group of people identify and communicate with one another and perceive the world. Thus, it is imperative to promote multilingualism and multiculturalism at every level of education, especially so in language teaching.

In the English Language classroom at degree level; students from different cultural and linguistic backgrounds are present; this linguistic diversity can be witnessed at micro level. It has also been observed that a large number of students face difficulty in expressing themselves in English. They often sit through the class finding the whole experience alien. This problem becomes more prominent in the case where a common language such as Hindi does not exist. Another problem that is encountered in these classes is that more often than not the texts available for teaching the target language, English in this case, are rooted in cultural contexts which are far removed from the lived experience of the students. Explaining while holding the attention of the students and making them familiar with such texts is often an exhausting task for students and teachers, resulting in a breakdown in the teaching learning process. While doing so one is often faced with the dilemma between continuing with Macaulay's policy of cultural imposition or working towards decolonization of mind which is often a project much talked about but rarely implemented in our education system. The authors have observed that with little encouragement and demonstration of a shared knowledge cultural knowledge goes a long way as far as breaking the initial hesitation is concerned. The main aim of the project has been to explore ways to include lived experiences of the students in the classroom and suggest ways for making ELT in Higher Education more engaging and culturally grounded.

Teachers have a critical role to play in encouraging and maintaining a culturally pluralistic society and upholding the idea and ideals of a nation. They have an opportunity to incorporate multicultural activities about diverse cultures as they organise their classroom activities. The activities they use should reflect India's diversity and allow students to share their similarities, develop a positive cultural identity, and appreciate the unique contributions of all cultures. The best way to incorporate multicultural literature, depicting the numerous

cultural practices of India, from Kashmir to Kanyakumari and Gujrat to Arunachal Pradesh, is to integrate it into the established reading program rather than as a separate or distinct area of study. The project aims to demonstrate the ways in which these can be integrated by incorporating diverse texts, reading and writing workshops and language experience approaches.

1.1 Literature Review

The driving question and consequently the research proposal has sprung out from the experience of the researchers in the real classrooms. The need to incorporate the cultural and linguistic background and to go beyond the suggested and prescribed texts surfaces in order to involve the students actively in the teaching learning process. The importance of culturally relevant texts on the learning outcome is a well-established fact. Numerous studies have explored the relationship between reading proficiency and cultural relevance of text (Ebe 2010, Feger 2006). The use of multilingualism as a classroom resource and creating inclusive classrooms that values cultural and linguistic diversity have also been well explored (Schechter 2004; Coelho 2004). In spite of several studies over decades teaching/learning in a multilingual classroom poses a challenge both for students as well as for teachers. Poudel (2010) discusses some of the major challenges in the multilingual classes in higher education.

There have been numerous studies (MAM, Garin, Domantay, and Rosals 2017) on the effect of contextualization and localization, in addressing a culturally and linguistically diverse classroom at school level. This diversity and issues related to it persists at college level as well. This project aims to find ways to address the needs of the diverse students at college level in English language classrooms and to examine how the socio-cultural and linguistic background of the student can be utilised so as to benefit everyone in the classroom. The study aims to analyse the effect of contextualised and localised information to accelerate the learning process of ESL (English and Second Language) along with promoting the idea of India as a nation by using the diversity as a teaching resource.

Kingston-Reese and Jagot (2021) discuss the widespread problem of teaching English in countries where it is not the language of the masses. There are several studies which address this issue. They discuss a short article in MAI journal's Toolkit series by Eugenia Zaroski where she critiques the conventional introductory exercises in the university classroom called "Where Do You Know From". The task illustrates the importance of attending conscientiously to the ways we relate to one another in the classroom as part of our

pedagogical and political responsibilities. In this piece, Kingston-Reese and Jagot discuss where they know from and how this knowledge has impacted their teaching, research, and development of the University of York's Decolonising Network. They further say that “by redirecting the social curiosity of knowing where others come from back onto the self, Zuroski encourages them to interrogate their own intellectual heritage, preoccupations, and gaps. Emphasising on the need to decolonize English Teaching they quote from Zuroski 2020, “How vital it is that 'settler scholars give serious thought to the ways in which even the most seemingly mundane academic structures and conventions can reproduce colonialist hierarchies of power' and 'alienate' students who can end up feeling that the institution 'disregards their ways of knowing and being’”

This project also highlights this point of academic structures making students feel ‘alienated’ and also ‘disregards their ways of knowing and being’. As India is a diverse country with different languages and cultures, studying in an English language classroom with Eurocentric text often makes students feel alienated and uninterested. Many times, students are unable to share their ideas and experiences in the classrooms due to the fear of it being unimportant. They also often fear mockery for not being well versed in English, for “their ways of being’ different from so called standards imposed through the text forced on them.

Reese and Jagot (2021) also discuss how students are not native to British or American history and have trouble contextualising its literature and culture with their own experience. This problem also persists in Indian English classrooms. As many times to explain Eurocentric text teachers have to go through a lengthy process in explaining the background of that country as students are not familiar with them. And this often makes students uninterested and the main idea of the text is often missed. Even if this process is successful it results in establishing and strengthening the western hegemony.

Privileging and inclusion of texts that connect to the lived experiences of the students can have far-reaching consequences not only in decolonizing education but also in promoting national integration. The English translations of the texts in Indian languages is one of the solutions as it may help students feel familiar to the texts and thus may increase interest in learning, but the relatedness of translated text is many times wary and the original context is nowhere to be seen. So, the teachers need to verify the relatedness of the translated text and make sure it is connected to its original context as much as possible. The NEP (New education policy) also suggests teachers to go through training in high-quality content as well

as pedagogy and to use multilingualism as a resource in English language teaching. All these methods suggested by NEP can help us to maintain the relatedness of the translated text.

Jefford (2021) explores the possibilities in decolonizing English language learning and emphasises that “decolonizing education remains one of the most important tasks for educators in the 21st century”. Citing de Beauvoir she says “Reading texts that glorify a White settler Canada and situate the coloniser as heroic subjects can cause racialized students and staff to internalise the colonial voice, reproduce racism and become complicit (de Beauvoir, 2011) in their own oppression.”(Jefford, 2021). She further points out “Discourse on imperialism situates the West as the Subject and continues to relegate non-Europeans as the shadowy other whose knowledge is continually subjugated, disqualified, and ignored by imperialistic legacies (Bhabha, 1995; Spivak, 1983). Mukherjee (1986) offers an example of how students can ignore the racial, social, and political contexts when given classroom materials with the dominant voice that enables the belief that human beings face similar dilemmas, leading to internalising the very ideas that oppress them. (Jefford, 2021)

Texts that glorify the European colonialists as a superior race and the epitome of success are incorporated right from the school, the idea that British imperialism was beneficial for India and its people is a common one in Indian society, students have to face bullying because of their English accents this explains some students’ fear of the English language, because of this cultural imposition the students subconscious is filled with a self-loathing and deep hatred for their cultural identities, the student faces a complete change of identity, the reflections of which can be seen in their clothing, attitude, blindly aping the western culture, and try to sound like a westerner with their fake English accents, these effects can be seen in all the former colonies. When students enter the English language classroom, they are alien to the western cultural texts being taught to them, but slowly through their English language classroom experience, they become alien to their own culture, and the music, art, movies, books, and novels they consume become western.

The author explains the new way in which the tentacles of western countries have entered the social fabric of former colonies due to the globalised world and the economic needs of former colonies they are forced to adopt the western way and methods of modernity, if they refuse they are called uncivilised, the institutions at all level mainly at the educational institutes seem to have been compromised, the indigenous teaching-learning method(guru - shishya pratha in context of India) were replaced by the colonial teaching methods and their

educational policies in former colonies still continue in some form or another. She mentions how Altbach (1971) “explains that Neo-colonialism is not direct control as in the past, but rather an indirect retaining of domination through planned policies and texts, specifically in education. Teachers with Western biases continue to promote White supremacy by utilising colonial textbooks, curricula, and administration patterns” (Jefford, 2021). The use of western texts still continues in English language classrooms where the supremacy of the white man and his culture is promoted while disrespecting indigenous point of views.

Keeping our research in line with India's NEP (2020) we try to produce findings and data which will help decolonize the teaching and learning of the English language. Anglophile teachers have a great role in continuing these western texts in the classroom.

In the case of India, many of the already scarce texts based on Indian cultures are from the western perspective, where they have been misrepresented and interpreted wrongly both in idea and language. In our research we try to promote the inclusion of texts written in English by Indian authors, which will also provide space to the cultures that currently lack representation in our educational institutes. It is needed to counter the western stereotypes and present Indian point of views to the forefront. In our research, we present the idea of introducing multicultural texts in the English language classroom and the idea of teaching local folktales, stories and philosophies through the English language to reduce the increasing gap between the learner and her cultural identity. “Subverting colonialism requires acknowledging that not only were intellectuals in formerly colonised countries drained of all content and form but their philosophies and beliefs were distorted. For these reasons, ESL instructors should use contemporary materials that reflect the racial identities of the learners in a positive light, to deconstruct colonial stereotypes.” (Jefford, 2021)

In the Indian context, we expect a backlash from anglophiles in Indian society and western society. Whenever something about promoting indigenous culture and nationalism is talked about, certain sections of society portray it as if some crime is being committed and the country is heading in degradation by doing away with the western legacy of colonisation. In the context of India, the NEP (2020) also faced backlash, also from English language teaching community, who misinterpret policies, importance has been given to the English language in the NEP (2020) and its indigenization, but the special status English had earlier at the expense of native languages will not continue with the new education policy, English will be treated like the other languages in India. In Other non-western countries that are not

economically strong, the government refuses to initiate change in the education system due to fear of political backlash.

Krishnaswamy (1971, 1998, 2006) dive deeply into the issues of the English language in India. He also conducted many experiments regarding these issues. He also prepared a custom-made English literature book for Indian students incorporating the literature from India and from other countries which suited for the Indian students. In a recent lecture he claimed that this book was removed from the curriculum despite the fact that the majority of the students had liked it. It was the teachers who had shown unwillingness to continue with the book. Instead of this book they preferred British literature for the students. Krishnaswamy (2020) points out the problem with British literature. For example, Shakespeare literature required knowledge of 16th century England and their lifestyle and students had a hard time connecting to them. So, it should not be recommended in UG or PG levels in universities. He highlights these issues regarding how our English education system is laid to colonized our minds and we should free ourselves from such system. His experimental book was taken back and he holds its responsibility on “teacher’s reluctance”. He further says “some teachers do not want to think beyond the syllabus and there is no thought on developing new methods of teaching or adapting to non-traditional methods. They don't want any different material as they just want to teach the prescribed readings. They don't want to adapt anything different because they find the existing system convenient and if new changes are incorporated then they will have to do a lot of homework before teaching” (Krishnaswamy 2020).

This project is also in line with some of the principles laid out in New Education Policy 2020 which emphasises the need of “promoting multilingualism and the power of language in teaching and learning” and the need to develop “life skills such as communication, cooperation, teamwork, and resilience”.

“As so many developed countries around the world have amply demonstrated, being well educated in one’s language, culture, and traditions is not a detriment but indeed a huge benefit to educational, social, and technological advancement. India’s languages are among the richest, most scientific, most beautiful, and most expressive in the world, with a huge body of ancient as well as modern literature (both prose and poetry), film, and music written in these languages that help form India’s national identity and wealth. For purposes of cultural enrichment as well as national integration, all young Indians should be aware of the

rich and vast array of languages of their country, and the treasures that they and their literature contain (NEP 14).”

The project aimed to bring the diverse languages and cultures of India to make English teaching not only culturally grounded but also culturally enriching.

2. METHODOLOGY

At various stages of the project different methods were applied which included methods of theoretical analysis related to sociocultural, pedagogical and methodological literature, survey and diagnostic methods (interviewing, questionnaires, testing) and observation methods. The study was carried out at University of Delhi covering more than 500 students and 35 faculty members of the department of English.

A pilot study was conducted to assist the research in selecting the appropriate methodology to apply to the study. During this pilot study it was realised that to collect the required data a mixture of methods would be needed, consequently both quantitative and qualitative approach for analysis would also be implemented. The methods decided for data collection were interview, questionnaire and classroom observation.

In the beginning extensive reading and analysis was done of prior researches, which were entirely or partly related to our research topic. Some pressing issues which were common in all the researches on which reading had been conducted were highlighted. There were also some unique problems which had come forth, in this research attempted to address these issues along with bringing out problems which the other researchers had missed.

It was decided that the research will be divided into two parts, in the first part data from students and teachers was collected through separate questionnaires and in the second part classroom-based experiments were conducted. For the students' questionnaire, questions were created which addressed the research topic; initially there were around 35 questions of both subjective and objective type. After a stringent process 24 questions were selected and then pilot testing of the questionnaire was conducted among the selected students, it was observed that these students found the questionnaire very lengthy and felt some questions were irrelevant which they did not feel comfortable answering. After receiving their

feedback, the questionnaire was reviewed for the third time and a decision was made to keep fourteen questions in the questionnaire which fulfilled the data requirement.

The questionnaire was divided into four sections: -

- The first section was designed to collect the basic information of the students
- In the second section the focus was on establishing the background of the student and their interest and views of the English language.
- In the third section, the aim was to highlight the problems related to English language syllabus and try to get the students' point of view.
- In the fourth section some reforms were suggested and the student's point of view on them.
- A section for feedback of the students regarding the questionnaire was also added.

Many problems were faced while collecting the student's responses in person, for example- sending the link of the questionnaire to every student in person was difficult. That is why the decision was made to create a QR code and put one stall at the entry gate of the college to get as many responses as possible.

For the teacher's questionnaire, most of the questions were subjective so the decision was made to use the interview method, where students approached teachers from different colleges in the English department and collected their responses by noting them on paper. The interviewers had the questionnaire with them for reference. Some teachers also allowed their interviews to be recorded. Since teachers are not available all the time because of their scheduled classes, the work was divided into pairs of two to overcome the difficulties of getting responses and getting the task done on target time.

After receiving sufficient responses from both teacher and students the work on data analysis was started, the data was already converted into charts and graphs with the help of software tools. After that the data was analysed and findings were studied and correlations were made with the problem statement and for further progress in the project.

3. ANALYSIS

3.1 Student Questionnaire data analysis

To know the attitude, aptitude, constraints and other related issues involved with English Language Teaching-Learning a questionnaire was prepared for the students. During the pilot study the need to include open ended questions was felt so the questionnaire included both closed and open-ended questions. The first section of the questionnaire sought the response regarding students' gender, native place, place of education, mother tongue, other languages known and the course they are enrolled in as these aspects have a direct implication on second language learning.

The next section started with the question regarding the liking for English language among students. The results show that around 80 percent of students like English as a language to some extent whereas 20 percent students were not comfortable with even the idea of English. This was followed by a question regarding the proficiency scale of students in English, where it was found that the majority of the students were intermediate or advanced level in English.

An important aspect of second language learning is the constraints students feel while conveying their thoughts in the target language and in the case of English it becomes more pronounced in India. So, the next question aimed to find out this. The data shows that 78.9 percent of students face constraints in conveying their thoughts in one way or the other. As in India when a student enters the college, she/he has already the knowledge of multiple languages it is imperative that these languages find a place in English classes as well and that the multilingualism should be treated a solution rather than a problem, the next question tried to find out students' opinion regarding the use of these languages in the English classrooms. The analysis of the response shows that around 70 percent of respondents were favouring the use of these languages in the English classroom. In order to find out the impact and interest of/in the English text being taught a question was framed to know whether they discussed the text taught outside the classroom. The data shows 52.3 percent of the responses were of view that they rarely do. This shows that the text taught is not able to generate adequate interest among the students. The analysis of the responses shows that one of the reasons for this disinterest can be the cultural alienation of the course content.

In a scenario where English is constantly held as a language of global communication, one of the major insecurities among the students is the fear of them being judged for their competence in English and this has been stamped by the responses where 85.8% of the students feel vulnerable to this judgement. The responses have been shown in the figure 1.1.

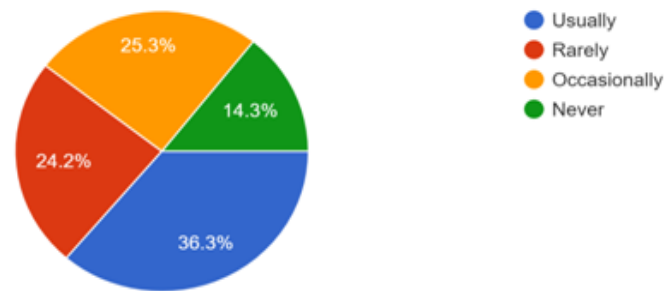


Figure 1.1: Showing the fear of being judged for competence in English

The focus was also made to make English language classes more relevant and interesting. In this regard students were provided with some options in the questionnaire. This question attempted to find out students' inclination towards different kinds of books. The result is as in figure no. 1.2

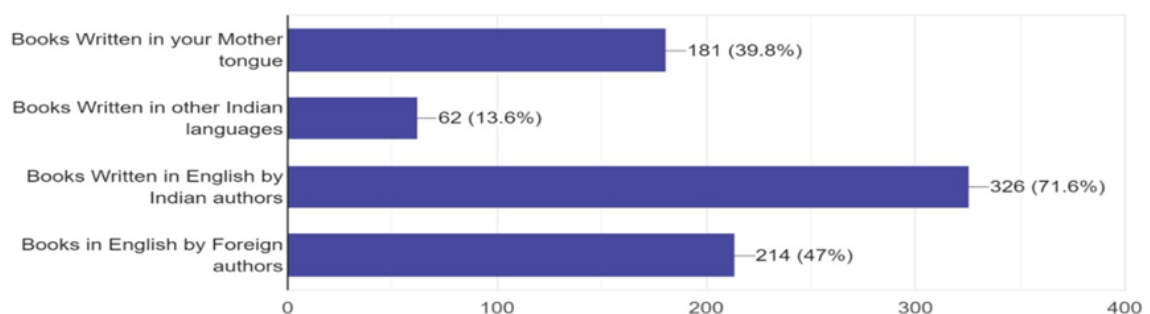


Figure 1.2: Showing students' inclination towards different kinds of books

Analysis shows that books written in English by Indian authors are preferred by 71.6 percent of students whereas 47 percent are also comfortable in books written by foreign authors. As in this question multiple options could be selected, we see that students prefer books written in English language as against the book written in other Indian languages. This can also be

due to the mass spread of English as a medium of instruction in India which puts pressure on students to excel in English Language. However, the highest percentage of students preferring books written in English by Indian authors suggests students' need, desire and interest in the subject and contexts nearer to home.

The students were also enquired about their understanding and awareness regarding their native literature.

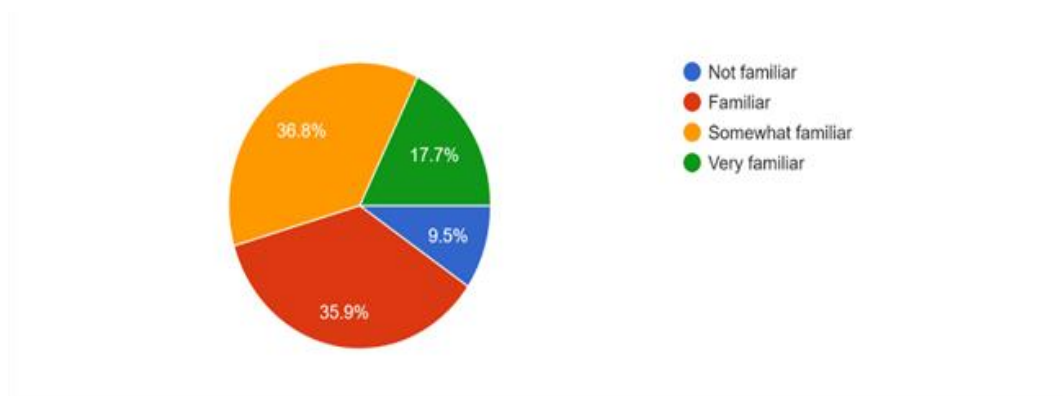


Figure 1.3: Showing student's awareness regarding their native literature

Based on the responses that were collected it was concluded that the majority of the students are aware of their native literature. Current English teaching learning majorly fails to include multicultural and multilingual content. The need was felt to incorporate these in the English classroom and it was further proved with the 73.8 percent favourable responses it got.

Questionnaire also included open-ended questions where students were asked to respond on various issues. The first question sought to elicit how inclusion of indigenous cultural texts, traditions and folktales will make English Language teaching/learning more enjoyable and easier to learn. Based on data collected, the majority of students believe that the inclusion of indigenous cultural texts, traditions, and folktales will make the English language more enjoyable and increase their understanding of the English language as the texts and materials will be more relatable to them. It could serve a double purpose by increasing their English proficiency, increasing their knowledge of their cultural past and traditions, and giving representation to the Indian perspective. India is full of people from different cultural backgrounds and most of these cultures continue to lack representation in the English language curriculum, the inclusion of texts from these various backgrounds would diversify the English language classrooms making space for learners with varied backgrounds to

connect more with their peers and give accommodations to different points of view in their classroom discussions with increased participation and more material to discuss, to this idea students have expressed deep and positive interest in their responses. People in Indian society continue to view English as an imposition, alien to their culture, our findings suggest by indigenizing the English language this viewpoint can be changed because in the current state of the globalised world English has become very important for students and professionals.

The next and the last question was asked about how bridging the gap between the culture of English and native language is essential for better understanding of both English and our culture. The opinion suggests that there is a gap between the culture of English and the Native language. Our majority of the talented youth shift to other countries for better opportunities. To keep our talented youth for the growth of our country, an action needs to be taken on the root of this problem, which is language. By incorporating English with Indian culture and diversities or by bridging the gaps between culture of English and the native language could be the possible solution to many of the problems that our education system faces nowadays.

3.2 Teacher's Interview Analysis

From the experience gained through students' questionnaire it was realised that to elicit the responses from the teacher's interview method will work better than questionnaire. Nonetheless, a questionnaire was prepared as a framework for conducting the interviews where the interviewer's focus was more on eliciting responses from the teachers rather than filling the questionnaire. This method gave sufficient data even if about thirty-five teachers were interviewed. Interviews ran for forty-five minutes to one and half hours giving the research group a good perspective on teachers' opinion regarding the issues related to this research. The teachers' questionnaire had two sections, first regarding general information and the second emphasised on the research questions and the last section focused on the solution and suggestions. Initially the questions were asked regarding the linguistic repertoire of the teachers. This also helped establish a comfortable space for further discussion.

The following graphs show the responses regarding Mother tongue/home language(s), and other language(s) in order of your proficiency of the teachers. This information was gathered to know if there is diversity among English language teachers in University of Delhi. Since University of Delhi is situated in the central part of the country therefore, the majority of the

teachers responded Hindi as their mother tongue and other languages as shown in the figure 2.1.

In the next question four domains were provided - Marketplace, College, Friends and Family to know language preferences of the teachers in their day-to-day life. The data shows that in the marketplace, 86.2 percent of the teachers prefer speaking Hindi, 3.4 percent of teachers prefer speaking English and 10.3 percent of the teachers speak both English and Hindi. In the College, 66.7 percent of the teachers prefer speaking English, 3.2 percent of teachers prefer speaking Hindi and 29 percent of the teachers speak both English and Hindi. Among Friends, 26.7 percent of the teachers prefer speaking Hindi, 36.7 percent of teachers prefer speaking English, 26.7 percent of the teachers speak both English and Hindi and 9.9 percent of the teachers speak other languages as shown in the figure 2.2.

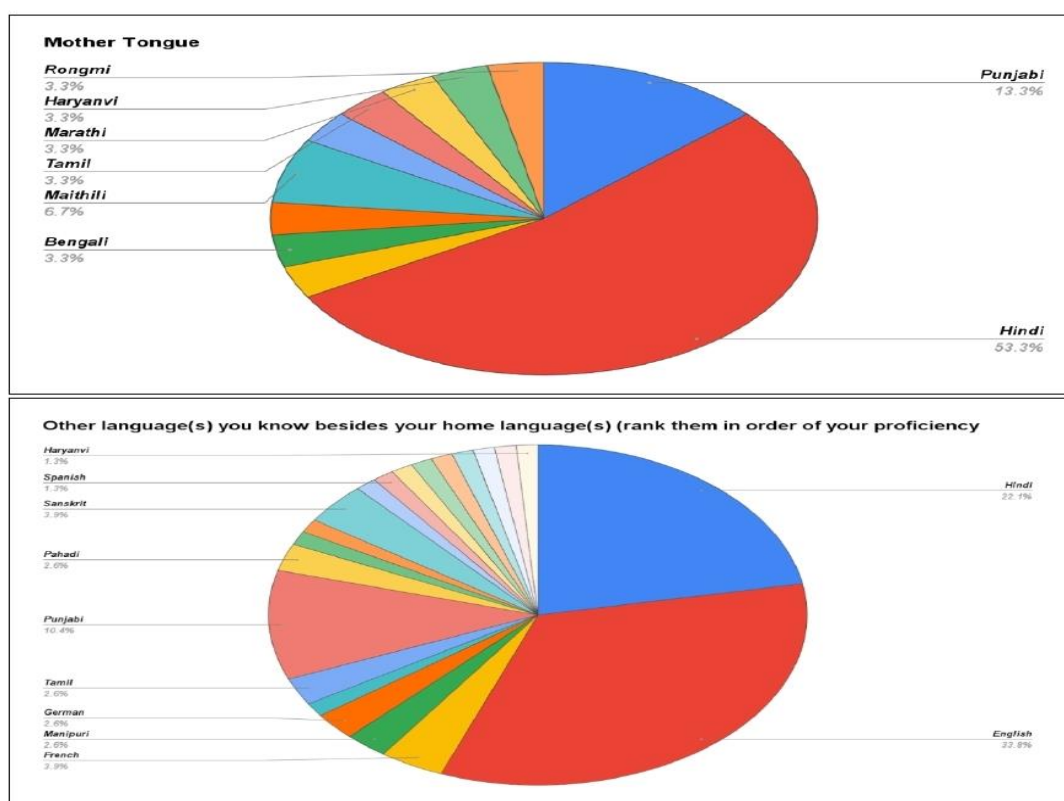


Figure 2.1: Showing mother tongue and proficiency of teachers in various languages

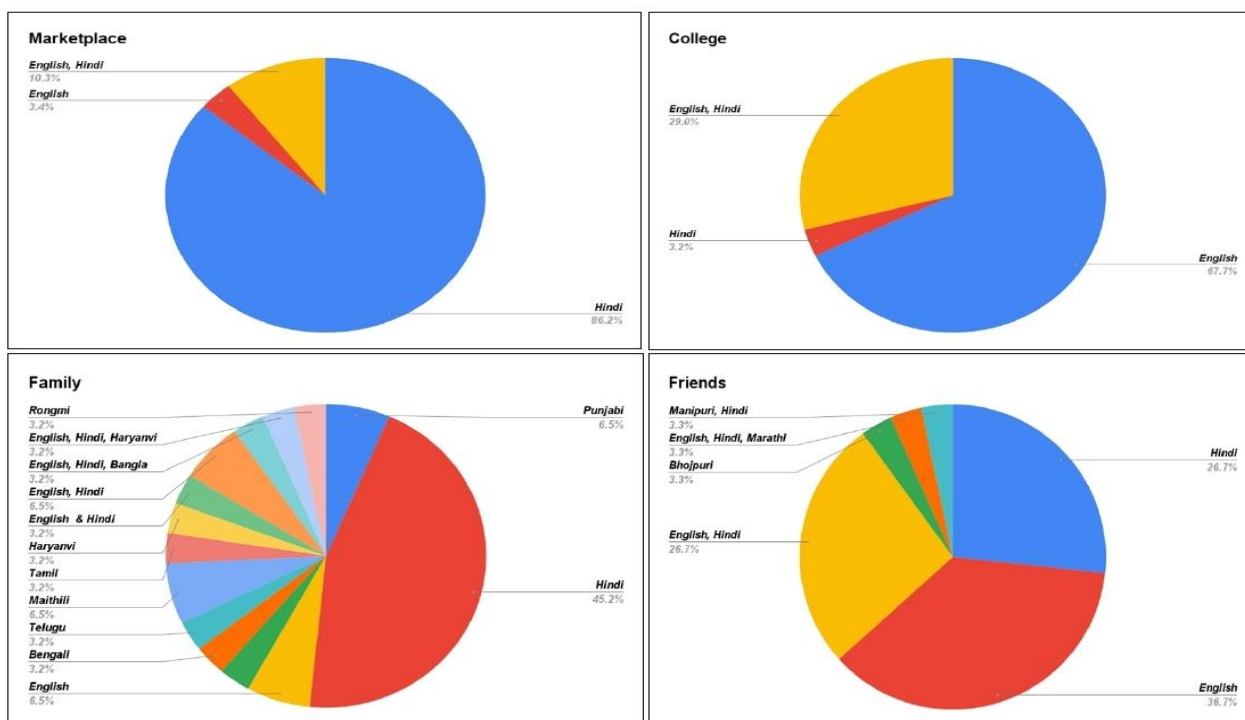


Figure 2.2: Showing language preferences of the teachers in their day-to-day life

In the next question teachers were asked “What language besides English do they use while teaching in the class”. In response to this question, the majority (67.6 percent) of the teachers prefer speaking Hindi and 8.7 percent of the teachers prefer other languages. 23.5 percent of the teachers do not speak any language other than English in their classroom as shown in figure 2.3.

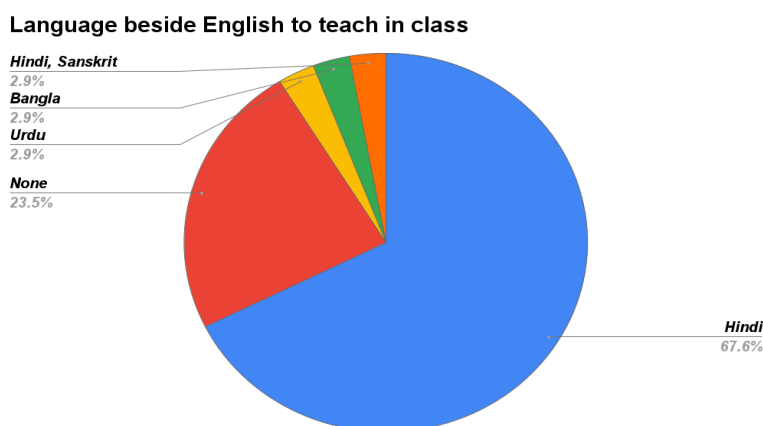


Figure 2.3: Showing languages teachers use beside English in the class

Along with this question they were also asked which language students use besides English to communicate with them inside the class as well as outside the class. Based on the responses, the majority of the students (87.1 percent) are comfortable communicating in Hindi, while 6.4

percent of the students prefer speaking other languages. Whereas 6.5 percent of the students do not speak any other language apart from English in their classroom as per figure 2.4.

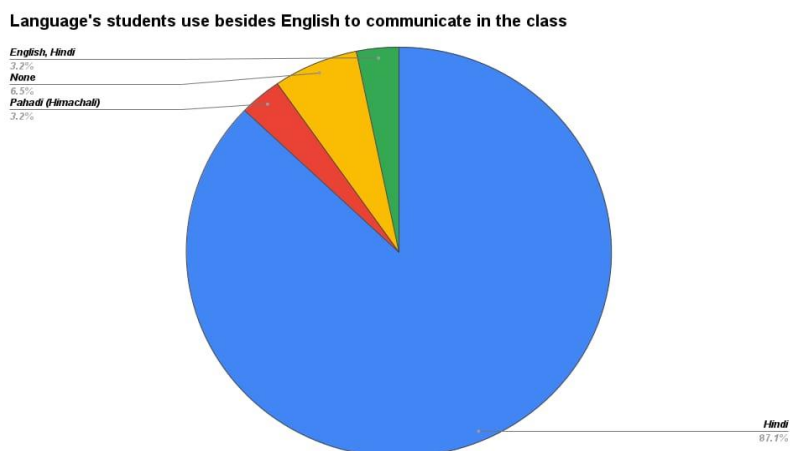


Figure 2.4: Showing languages student use with teachers inside the class room

According to the teachers, Majority of the students (80.6 percent) prefer speaking in Hindi outside the classroom whereas, 19.4 percent only speak English to communicate with teachers outside the classroom as per figure 2.5.

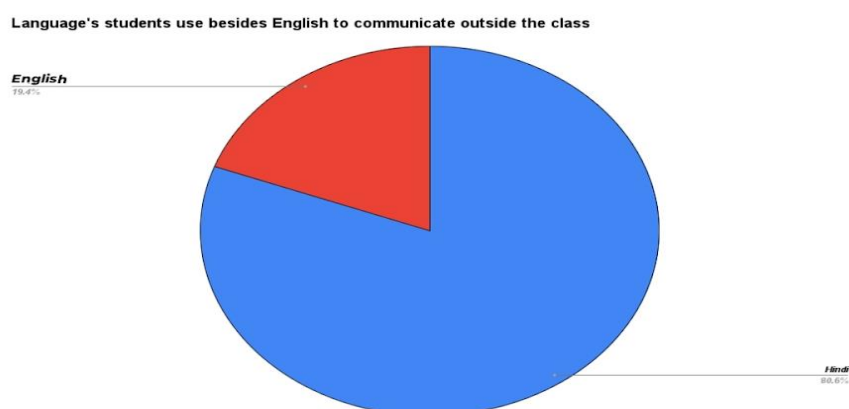


Figure 2.5: Showing languages student use with teachers outside the class room

In the section which followed mainly open-ended answers were sought. The first question was regarding the teachers' opinion on the problem faced by students in the English language class where the common language such as Hindi does not exist. The question asked was "What problems do you think non-Hindi/non-English speaking children face in your classroom?"

Analysis of the responses suggests that the majority of the teachers do not feel that such a problem exists. In their opinion the students have good competence in English and in the case where they lack, there is always a common language like Hindi to bridge the gap though according to them it's a rarity. When asked to explain the situation with non-Hindi speakers such as students from north-eastern and the southern part of the country, such teachers were of the opinion that students are fluent in English to receive instructions as compared to the students who belong to the northern and central parts of the country.

On the other hand, they also admitted that even if such students face any problems in speaking English, most of these students (including Non-Hindi and Non-English-speaking students) do not convey this and prefer to keep quiet. The analysis also suggests that the teachers blame this apathy towards learning on the students rather than on the syllabus, methodology or the academic structure. In contrast, some teachers said that students who are primarily non-Hindi and Non-English speaking do not understand the concepts or find it difficult to relate to some of the texts which are being taught in the classroom. Such teachers also emphasized on the need to include texts and methodology of teaching which is relatable for the students.

University of Delhi is a host to students from varied language backgrounds and considering this issue through this question the researchers tried to understand if this variation brings any problem to the teachers while giving instructions to the students in the English classroom and if yes how do they resolve it. The question asked was "Have you ever been in a situation where you had difficulty in conveying your message to the students with different language backgrounds?"

In response to this question, the majority of the teachers said that they do not find any problem in conveying their message to the students with different language backgrounds as they are well versed to explain the concepts to the students and make them understand it thoroughly. Some teachers on the other hand explained some situations in which they faced this and they also explained their ways of reaching a solution. It was also observed that most of the teachers took this question as a challenge to their capability as a teacher rather than a situation arising due to the constitution of the class hence most of the answers were extremely defensive in nature.

The next question focused directly on the method of teaching and the question asked was if the teachers encourage students to share their lived experience in the classroom and if it helps to break the communication barrier. If yes, what steps have they taken to encourage them to share it.

Analysis of the interaction with the teachers suggests that the teachers do ask students to share their lived experiences in the classroom. Most of the teachers mentioned that it is their introductory class where this is done to create a healthy environment in the classroom. They encourage the students to communicate with teachers and within the peer group to break the communication barrier.

Teachers used different methods to make their students comfortable in the English classroom. Some of them mentioned asking students to write their cultural folktales and share them in the classroom with everyone. Also, they keep it in the form of assignments, and diary entries as well. Some teachers also shared the opinion that students should be given full autonomy over the choice of the topic they want to discuss in the classroom.

The next point was to have the teachers' opinion on the necessity of the use of the learner's language and cultural references in the class at the university level and if yes what should be done to promote this. In response to these questions most of the teachers did not support the idea of including the learner's language in the classroom since it would not be feasible for the teachers to learn a variety of languages but most of the teachers responded positively for the use of cultural references in the classroom.

Some of the teachers said that in terms of bringing cultural references through the English language, English does it all the time. One teacher shared, "that's what English Hons is all about. We are not only doing it in the case of India but we do it globally. We take the perspective of the whole world, we celebrate the differences of diverse cultures and we believe in multiculturalism that is what we are about. We try to teach students in a way that they not only understand but also, they can critically analyse it. We do not only read these texts of different cultures but also, we accept and celebrate the Indian and globalised cultural diversity."

According to some teachers' who favoured the idea of changing the syllabus to incorporate the cultural references of the students "literature should be seen through the lens of cultural

surroundings of the students so that they feel connected to it and relate with it. Whatever they read and learn should be connected to the cultural grounds so that they can retain the concepts and understand them better.

One of the key suggestions in the NEP 2020 is that the medium of instruction until at least grade five, but preferably till grade eight and beyond will be the home language/ mother language/ local language. These languages and students' knowledge systems should find a place in upper and higher-level classrooms also. The lack of such incorporation will alienate these students from the students who are more fluent in English. Thereafter, home language or local language shall continue to be included and respected everywhere otherwise it gives rise to insecurity among such students and other students are barred from learning the knowledge these students have to offer. Through this question we tried to find out if we can use multilingual teaching methods at college level too. Here it is also important to note that a multilingual teaching method doesn't expect teachers to be fluent in the learner's language but to have an inclination and respect to include students' knowledge.

When encountered with this question, the majority of the teachers assume that students who study English Honours are proficient in English and they should strictly adhere to English while teaching in the classroom. They feel that it would be beneficial for the students to learn the vocabulary and sentence formation in the English language. It suggests that among the teachers the discipline is treated as sacrosanct and there is no need of altering it in any way. They outrightly denied the scope for any such inclusion.

Among the teachers who teach English language classes, some said that multilingual teaching methods are better but it would be somewhat problematic as students from different region's students come at the university level. Given the situation, multilingual teaching methods are difficult due to the presence of vast numbers of languages. One teacher said "some students don't have Hindi proficiency; some know Punjabi or Maithili. Everybody should understand one common language and reduce the communication gap; therefore, the multilingual teaching method would cause problems for some students" Some teachers were of opinion that "India is such a diverse country with 22 official languages and there are many other dialects, it's not feasible for a teacher to carry forward multilingual teaching methods". Also, "it's not easy to translate various cultural texts from all around the country into English overnight". They also feel that "in the Indian context also it is not practically possible for

teachers to learn all these languages since they are teaching English so they are supposed to speak English and talk to students in English only to provide them with the proper Environment to learn English language.”

One of the teachers suggested the introduction of skill-based courses for teachers to adapt to different cultures. This will equip them to deal with students’ linguistic and cultural variation.

NEP 2020 suggests that multilingualism and multiculturalism of India should be promoted and keeping this in mind the next question focused on exploring teachers’ opinion by asking if they think that multilingual/multicultural text can be used in the English classroom.

In response to this question, the majority of the teachers agreed that multicultural text can be used in the classroom. Teachers teaching literature courses mentioned that multicultural text already exists in the English literature syllabus. They suggested that more multicultural text focusing on India should be added in the English language syllabus and especially for courses where English is taught as a language. For the students of English literature, they were of the opinion that literature from all around the world should be learnt to broaden their horizon and understand different perspectives. They were of the opinion that if the cultural context of the text is far removed from students’ culture it is the responsibility of the teachers to make it relatable and teach the students to critically analyse the text.

Also there is one more perspective of a teacher that “we need to understand the literature, you cannot just put any texts in the curriculum, she then said it is not a book that you buy from railway station to read in your leisure time in fact it should be something that shakes you from inside and changes you so that when you leave the college after three years you have a broader perspective and a critical mind then she continued by saying that, by reading good literature of any language students will know their own hearts better but since it is the English literature we try to do it with English texts of those who are tested by time over the years be it Premchand, Kalidasa, Mahadevi Verma, Manto or Shakespeare”.

Through the data collected through the students’ questionnaire. Reasons for their disinterest in English classes were sought, the euro centrism of the text emerged as one of the main reasons. Thus, the teachers were asked if they feel the students are disinterested in Eurocentric texts. With the question the intention was to understand the present scenario of

the percentage of Eurocentric texts in the English curriculum and also what teachers think about that and how they feel students respond to those texts.

The responses of the teachers can be bifurcated into two categories: one who teaches English literature courses and the other who teach English Language courses. According to some of the teachers of literature courses there is absolutely no problem with the syllabus; they were of the opinion that “the students have to broaden their perspective while understanding English literature”. Another teacher mentioned that she has been teaching Mahabharata, Cilappatikaram and Mrcchakatika for a very long time and she believes that if you are teaching English then there is no need to fear a Eurocentric view. She also emphasized that “English literature has some of the finest writers from India” and when she teaches “Alfred Tennyson poem in which he talks about mutiny” she “criticises the poem...that’s what they try to do at university” but according to her “the more dangerous thing is, going to the class telling the students that Mahabharata is the only text that they have and there is no other epic that exist and that is problematic”.

There are teachers who believe that “literature should not be seen through the lens of language because it will limit the horizon and understanding of the students”. They are of the opinion that “literature is the study of human heart, emotions, and motivations and also it is the mirror to the society. It talks about the social concern and problems of different societies so literature should not be bound to any country as they have universal themes embedded in it.. be it great literature of India or England and that if we limit ourselves to just one type of text it will kill the purpose of literature which is to understand and make peace with different perspectives”. So, in their opinion “English literature should not be judged in the prism of language or culture rather it should be judged by the test of time. Some teachers also said that those Eurocentric texts which students cannot connect with should be taught through an Indian perspective. The themes of those good texts are still relevant in any part of the world.” One of the teachers mentioned that “it takes extra effort to understand the context of the western text and once we start students teaching the concept and find them not taking interest in the classroom then it becomes very difficult for us to keep on going. In fact, teachers think that they can use that particular time to connect with students and make them comfortable in the classroom even when they are not fluent in the English language. We can allot that extra effort to the students in the classroom keeping in mind their different cultural background and their level of understanding”.

So, after analysing the interviews of the teachers of both literature and language courses it can be derived that at least some teachers feel the need to change the curriculum of English language and pedagogical method.

English being a language of imposition for political economical as well as cultural colonisation. The English language cannot establish a cultural connection with Indians and still remains an alien language for a large population. So, the next question was asked to elicit a response regarding teachers' stance on the difficulty English poses on students in communicating their ideas freely.

Many teachers said that "students especially from non-literature courses face difficulty at many levels. They mentioned that students face problems in understanding the texts especially for non-Hindi speakers as they cannot relate with the literature and do not understand the language. They also find these texts very culturally disconnected from their environment because of that they can neither understand nor relate to those texts. In addition to that, students who are not good at English are hesitant to speak freely or ask doubts in the class as they feel judged by their peers".

The pressure of judgement on students with regard to their competence in English has already been established through the analysis of students' response. The same fact has also been established here by the teachers. Some teachers first ask their students in English class whether they are okay with English or if it would be more comfortable to use a mix of English and Hindi. Also, one of the teachers said that she curates the readings as per the classroom requirements in each semester.

As one of the aims of the introduction of English in India was the promotion of British culture, the next question intended to know the opinion of teachers on the promotion of Indian literature and culture through the English language and how they feel about teaching it. The analysis of the responses suggest that most of the teachers did not interpret the question in its full sense and they focused more on promoting Indian literature but they neglected the point of promoting culture through the English language.

In response to this question the teachers feel good about teaching Indian literature but when the interviewers emphasised on the balance between Eurocentric texts and Indo centric texts, varied responses were received. Some teachers said that "there should be a balance between

the two of them, students need to have their own perspective and in order to gain that we need to teach them different texts from all around the world” whereas some suggested that “there should not be a balance between the two, in fact twenty percentage should be texts from all around the world and eighty percent should be Indo - centric texts as we need to learn more about our own culture first then only we should move forward and learn cultural texts of different countries. If we see the curriculum of various countries, they teach their culture and value system to their youth so this is high time that we start taking initiative to teach our youth the texts which hold Indian value systems and inculcate Indo-centric texts”.

Through the next question the intention was to find out, while teaching students text related to their culture, do they feel more interested and are they able to put through their points in the classroom, could the feelings of alienation be removed by incorporating cultural texts and does this improve the overall English language classroom experience.

The teachers of language courses said that “the students show their participation when they are taught Indian literature as it makes the English language class more interesting and interactive. Also, students can relate with the texts and understand the diverse Indian culture”. They were of the opinion that “inclusion of more Indo-centric text will make the English language teaching more culturally rooted”.

But according to some of the English literature teachers, “students are interested in Indian literature as well as literature from all around the world. According to those teachers “their students respond positively to any kind of literature and they feel that all students in their class actively participate and always put through their points in the classroom. Such teachers suggested that they “never noticed any feeling of alienation in the classroom due to the text that they teach”.

As the National Education Policy 2020 is trying to make education more Indo centric, the question was based upon the recommendation of NEP 2020 which suggests “inclusion of Indian culture and value system”. The question was asked if it can be introduced in English class as well.

This question generated some very interesting responses. Some teachers were out rightly agitated on the mention of NEP whereas some others gave very favourable responses in favour of its recommendation. Some of the teachers avoided answering the question saying

that “I do not know anything about NEP so I will not answer it.” One of the teachers got agitated while answering the question regarding NEP and she said that “she is not going to make any political statement”. Some of the teachers welcomed NEP’s recommendation and hailed it as an initiative to incorporate Indic cultural texts and value systems in the curriculum since they strongly believe that Indian culture and value system must be included. One of the teachers said that in the current paradigm “we teach various texts and every text has its own value and those texts are more conflicting and materialistic whereas our culture is more spiritual, we not only need to read that but to read texts related to nature of spirit etc. If this policy is implemented well then it will bring a positive impact on students as one of the teachers and that it will encourage the students to read and understand the text as they have shared nationality”. Some teachers hoped that it would prove to be a turning point in Indian education.

One of the teachers does not think that “it will make them more aware of their own culture and value system or knowledge. After adding the cultural references or value system will the students feel connected to the language is questionable.” One of the teachers emphasised that “it is already happening through English literature papers and is working very well; we already have a cultural diversity paper. In the future this must be promoted but not at the cost of texts from around the world. English acts as a global bridge for communication.” Some of the teachers felt that “English is no longer a foreign language for us. It is very much a part of our life and experience and to make it more accessible, understandable and relatable we should make it more Indic cultural centric as prescribed in NEP. It will make the English language very Indianized and once it is done, the English language will become easier even for a layman.”

When asked the question, “will the inclusion of text rooted in Indian culture in the English curriculum change the student behaviour, interest and participation in the English class?” One of the teachers said that the “English language should be considered as a native language, if we do not see the English Language from the Indian perspective then it would be really difficult for us to learn it. Another teacher disagreed that text rooted in the English language curriculum can change the behaviour of the students or develop their interest in the classroom.

Whereas Majority of the teachers mentioned that if we teach students Indian centric text then it will definitely bring positive responses from the students and will make the class more interesting not only for the students but also for the teachers.

3.3 Combined Analysis

This section presents combined analysis to understand and highlight the differences, contradictions and overlapping between the opinions of teachers and students. Through the analysis of teachers' and students' responses, an attempt was made to understand the problems in the English language course and the Pedagogy of teaching the English language.

Teachers were mostly of the opinion that there are no issues with the English curriculum, all the texts that are given in the English curriculum are important and the methodology caters to the learning needs of the students, but the analysis of the students' responses suggests otherwise. When the students were asked to rate their liking for the English language on a scale of 1 to 5, (where 1 is the least and 5 is the most) 43.8% of the students chose 5. Whereas when they were asked to rate their proficiency in English on a scale of 1 to 5, only 15% choose 5. This data clearly shows that the students are very keen in learning the language but the curriculum is designed and/or imparted in a way that hinders learning. Also, almost 78.5% of students feel constraints while conveying their thoughts in English. So, it becomes very evident that students do not feel that everything is fine with the English curriculum.

While some other teachers agreed that there are some problems with the English curriculum and for making it relevant changes need to be done. Especially in case of language courses, they suggested the inclusion of more Indo centric texts to make the English language relatable to different students. One of the teachers explained with example “in order to explain to the students how Daffodils look like I need to give an example of some Indian flowers so that they can easily relate to it” so rather than reading the poem “Daffodils” it would be better to bring texts which are related to their surrounding their culture”. These teachers agreed that the curriculum for the English language needs to be changed and it needs to be Indianized. The teachers teaching language courses were mostly against any kind of change and often adopted a supercilious attitude while talking about the students who face problems in English language. Apart from all these, some of the teachers took this question very personally, perceiving it to be an attack on their ability to teach the English language. In

such cases the answers were mostly diplomatic “Neither they nor their students face any sort of problems”.

About the use of multilingual approach of teaching most teachers were of view that it is not needed while as has been mentioned above almost 78.9% of students feel constraints while conveying their thoughts in English and about 66.7% of students feel that they would prefer the use of their mother tongue sometimes in an English classroom as it will make English easy to understand. This re-emphasizes that there is something amiss in the way students’ problem is considered in the teaching-learning process.

Some other teachers also added that multilingualism is the way ahead in classroom teaching and in no way a hindrance to the teaching of the English language in the classroom as they believe that students from English language courses feel difficulty in expressing their ideas freely therefore if we use multilingual teaching method it will give a boost to students’ participation, accelerate learning and help in achieving learning outcomes more effectively.

One of the teachers said that “Different teachers should be recruited from different language and cultural backgrounds so that it would do justice to diverse Indic culture”. Regarding this the example was given saying that “if a text from a Malayali writer is being taught in the class, then a teacher who knows Malayali culture should teach that text so that students could really understand the themes, underline meaning and the world-building created by the text”.

When we asked the Teachers what they think about the addition of multilingual texts in the curriculum of the English language. Some of the teachers said that multilingual texts should be added to the English language curriculum as it will make the English language easier and more understandable to students of different backgrounds. But they raised a concern that those multilingual texts that have been added need to be translated correctly so that the emotions and themes that are highlighted in the original texts could be understood in the translations also. One of the teachers said that it will make the English language class interesting and interactive. Also, students will be able to understand it better as they can relate to the texts and acknowledge the diverse culture of India. As it will make the English class more rooted. The majority of students believed that the inclusion of indigenous cultural texts, traditions, and folktales will make the English language more enjoyable and increase their understanding of the English language as the texts and materials will be more relatable to them and it will make English class more interesting.

Some of the students reiterated the fact that India is full of people from different cultural backgrounds and most of these cultures continue to lack representation in the English language curriculum, the inclusion of texts from these various backgrounds would diversify the English language classrooms making space for learners with varied backgrounds to connect more with their peers and give accommodations to different points of view in their classroom discussions with increased participation and more material to discuss, to this idea students have expressed deep and positive interest in their responses.

With this analysis, it was pretty clear that the opinions of teachers and students are almost the same and they both agreed that multilingual texts need to be added to the curriculum of English language as it will make the English language class more interactive and it will give a better environment for the students to learn and understand English more easily.

4 EXPERIMENTATION

The aim of the research was to make the English teaching-learning process multicultural and multilingual. After analysing responses from the teachers and students it was found out that there is an issue in the English curriculum and students feel disconnected from the English classes because English teaching is being done in a vacuum. So as a part of the project an experiment was conducted to make the English curriculum multicultural, multilingual and multidisciplinary at the same time so that students could relate to the teaching, feel interested and connected to the class. To incorporate these, an English language classroom was chosen for the experimental work. As the paper “English Language through Literature” for BA and B.Com programme courses gives flexibility regarding the text, it was well suited for this purpose.

Introductory sessions with the students were conducted and the interests of each student were evaluated, their likings and their career aspirations for the future. Through this, the researchers got to know the interest and needs of the students. After this, many brainstorming sessions were conducted and thereafter seven topics were selected with the help of students themselves. Due to the short duration of the lecture and the number of classes in the semester being limited, the students were divided into seven groups and each group was assigned a topic. The other motive for grouping the students was to make them learn coordination, group management, engagement etc.

These topics include a novel Bachelor of Arts by RK Narayan, Education and Significance of Life by J. Krishnamurthy, English studies in India, Swami Vivekananda, Indian art and architecture, North Eastern states Focusing on the Language and cultures and NewYear in different states of India. The reasoning behind choosing these topics was primarily students' interest, the ability and flexibility they provided to bring their lived experiences to the centre and their usefulness in connecting it to their career goals, and the possibility it provided for research and for promoting national integration.

Topics were selected in a way which required thorough research for a better understanding. Each group was asked to make a presentation on the assigned topic. The motive was to make their learning process interesting and relevant and we also wanted actual learning to take place in the classroom.

It was satisfying to notice that students who showed a lack of interest and participation earlier in the classes are now showing their interest. Most of them really enjoyed and learnt through the process of presentation and also from others' presentations. It made the class engaging, interactive and made English learning easy rather than a burden. It was also surprising to notice that The learning process becomes interesting and informative when students feel part of the teaching process and it was interesting to notice the enthusiasm of the students for the presentation of their learning of the different topics. This is the kind of interest and engagement that is expected from a student in a classroom. And many students have asked for the conduction of this kind of activity on a regular basis as it makes learning very easy, enjoyable and interactive. The researchers noticed that learning through this method will also yield better results. The students were asked to give feedback regarding the experiment. They responded by saying that “this process of teaching was very insightful and knowledgeable as they learned new things. They also said that the process of teaching was not monotonous, rather it was interesting and interactive and it made English learning enjoyable.” They also learned to cooperate with their group members. At first, some students were nervous before giving the presentation because it was a big deal for them to talk in front of the whole class but after they finished their presentation the students said that “the process worked as a confidence booster”.

The students also provided their feedback regarding the experiment. They said that this process of teaching was very insightful and knowledgeable as they learned new things. They also said that the process of teaching was not monotonous rather it was interesting, interactive and it made English learning enjoyable .They also learned to cooperate among the group mates and time management. The students told it was a confidence booster environment for them and it nourished their speaking, writing and speaking skill which is most important in today's time for them. One of the student stated that “It was really insightful to work with all my fellow members. I personally learnt a lot from the topic which was given to me. Rather than that I also learnt many more besides the topic like people management, ppt making and all that and yeah it was really heart warming, working with all dear friends.” It was satisfying to notice that non-interactive students showed keen interest in this learning process. Many students have asked for conduction of this kind of activity on a regular basis. This research thus recommends that in the teaching learning process, learning rather than teaching must be made central. It is not what and how teachers teach but what and how students learn is important.

5 RESULT AND DISCUSSION

From the above analysis and discussion it is clear that there is an urgency to rethink and reinvigorate the English studies in India. The text, context and the teaching method largely remains the same as it was when it was introduced by the Britishers from a position of power. Given the fact that a language, once it is part of the social fabric of a society, it cannot be dispensed with. Given the situation of India where English is deep rooted in the social, judicial and educational fabric but not the language of the masses. The need of the hour is to utilise this language for the promotion of India's cultural and national epochs.

There is clearly a gap between the texts that are being taught, methodology being followed and the social cultural fabric the students are part of. The research has clearly shown and it is being reiterated here that students' way of living and being must not only be respected but it must also be incorporated in the educational system. For this, incorporating the multilingualism and multiculturalism of the country is certainly a way ahead. It should be kept in mind while designing syllabuses and prescribing teaching methodologies. Teachers should be provided refresher courses on a regular basis in order to be truly emancipated to think beyond the prescribed syllabus and also to get out of their comfort zones to make the teaching-learning process more meaningful and result oriented.

The point of the project; there is an urgency with which the decolonization of education, particularly of English education should be envisioned and implemented; becomes clear from the view of teachers in the above discussion, is considered. Glorifying the text which "situate the coloniser as heroic subjects" have caused the teachers "to internalise the colonial voice, reproduce racism and become complicit" and be an agent in their own oppression as pointed in the discussion above by jefford (2021). Teachers claiming the "literature of all places being same" miss the point that these so called harmless texts are often full of hidden agenda and how it forces the students to "ignore the racial, social, and political contexts when given classroom materials with the dominant voice that enables the belief that human beings face similar dilemmas, leading to internalising the very ideas that oppress them as pointed out by Mukherjee (1986).

The project also clearly emphasises that the Indian education system should focus more on the concerns faced by the country in a way that promotes the feeling of self respect among the students. It can only be done when the system shows a respect for the knowledge of their

culture and especially of their language finds place in the curriculum throughout. Since English is a major factor which contributes to the low self esteem among the students, it should be taught while making the students aware that it is just one of the languages and they already possess the competence of multiple languages. This can be done by adopting a multilingual approach of language teaching. Education in India should free itself from western biases and should stop promoting white supremacy which is done by “utilising colonial textbooks, curricula, and administration patterns” as pointed in Jefford 2021.

This project 'Socio-Cultural Assimilation: Integrating Multiculturalism and Multilingualism in English Classes at College Level' displays the importance of integrating multiculturalism and multilingualism in English classes for the students of the college. Since the study is limited in its scope many dimensions could not be taken. The data set that came primarily from one university can also be seen as one limitation. At the same time it should be noted that this university has students from all over India and due to its location has a common language i.e. Hindi for the majority of the students, still faces problems of cultural and linguistic gaps. If such studies are conducted at a bigger level this problem will be more pronounced. Thus, this study certainly shows a way forward for incorporating multiculturalism and multilingualism in India in t English classrooms.

6 CONCLUSION

Rather than focusing on lecture mode a classroom should be a ground for exploration of new ideas and it is also important to note that students' ways of knowing and being should not only be respected, it should also be accounted for throughout the teaching learning process. In order to do so there should be incorporation of their existing cultural norms, cultural texts and history and also their native languages. Along with that we must also focus on improving their knowledge of social surroundings. The English teaching process and the curriculum needs to be revolutionised, the same old process cannot work in these changing times.

The first section of the report introduces the idea and the rationale of the project followed by the section of literature review where the work related with the project, their main ideas, findings and their relatedness of the project has been discussed. The third section clearly delineates the methodology for the project. The fourth and fifth section presents an in depth analysis of the data collected from students and teachers respectively. In the next section that follows a combined and comparative analysis of the above mentioned data along with discussion has been presented. The seventh section deals with the experimentation that followed the analysis and discussion. The eighth section presents the result and discussion of the entire project. Some of the major recommendations of the project are as follows:

- In every class the learners should be respected, there should be a regard for the socio-cultural background they come from, the languages they know and the worldview they have.
- A teacher needs to establish an environment of mutual respect and it is not necessary for them to know the language and culture of the students but they must have a regard for it.
- Classroom should not be syllabus oriented; it should rather be oriented towards students. In every class the students and the teachers should have the flexibility to explore the text of their choice.
- English language teaching should orient itself towards knowing the rich heritage of India. It will not only familiarise the students with the past but also prepare them to handle the future better.

- Multilingual teaching approach does not always mean that the teachers are proficient in all the languages; rather they should show respect and understanding for the knowledge of the students.
- In every language classroom there should be a discussion about existing knowledge of the students. Their cultural norms and their languages.

The above mentioned recommendations are the ideas which spring from this project which opens the door for further research. It is imperative to do further research in this area in different parts of the country taking into account the different data set which was not possible given the limited scope of this project.

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8 ANNEXURE

8.1 Annexure 1: Questionnaire (Students)

Description

The purpose of this research project is to explore ways to include lived experiences of the students in the classroom and suggest ways for making English language teaching in higher education more engaging and culturally grounded. Answer the following questions based on your belief. Your responses will be anonymous and will never be linked to you personally. Your Participation is entirely voluntary. If there are items you do not feel comfortable answering, please skip them. Thank you for your cooperation.

Choose Your Occupation:

- School Student
- College Student
- Job
- Unemployed
- Business

Section A: Basic Information

Gender:

- Male
- Female
- Other

Course:

Mother Tongue: _____

Native(ancestral) Place: _____

Place of Primary Education: _____

Place of Secondary Education: _____

Language Known: _____

Section B: Establishing the background of the student and their interest and views of the English language.

1. On a scale of 1 to 5 how much do you like the English language
 - 1 (Least)
 - 2
 - 3
 - 4
 - 5 (Most)
2. On a scale of 1 to 5 rate your level of English proficiency.

Beginner 1 2 3 4 5 Expert
3. Do you feel any constraints or shortcomings while conveying your thoughts in English
 - Yes
 - No
 - Sometimes
4. Do you prefer the use of your mother tongue in an English language classroom for easier understanding of the subject?
 - Yes
 - No
 - Sometimes
 - Rarely
5. On the scale of 1-5 rate importance of English in the following domain:
 - a) Academics _____
 - b) Professional career _____
 - c) Culturally _____
 - d) Socially _____
 - e) Communication _____
6. Across the following domains, what language do you prefer to speak?

a) Family

b) College

c) Friends

d) Marketplace

Assamese

Bengali

Gujarati

Hindi

Kannada

Kashmiri

Konkani

Malayalam

Manipuri

Marathi

Nepali

Oriya

Punjabi

Sanskrit

Sindhi

Tamil

Telugu

Urdu

Bodo

Santhali

Maithili

Dogri

6.2 If other kindly mention the language

Section C: Highlighting the problems related to English language syllabus and trying to get the students' point of view

7. Do you discuss the text taught in class, outside the classroom?
- Yes, it is relevant
 - No, it's not relevant
 - Sometimes
 - Rarely
8. Do you think that your peers judge others by their competence in English?
- Usually
 - Rarely
 - Occasionally
 - Never

Section D: Reforms needed and the student's point of view on it.

9. Which type of literature do you prefer reading?
- Books Written in your mother tongue
 - Books Written in other Indian languages
 - Books Written in English by Indian authors
 - Books in English by Foreign authors
10. How do you think English language class can be made more relevant and interesting?
- By including contemporary Indian issues.
 - By introducing popular Indian literature.
 - By introducing popular foreign literature
 - By introducing topics related to your culture, tradition and folktales
 - By including debates and discussions
 - By including Prose, Articles & Novels in the reading.
 - Other _____
11. How familiar are you with your native language literature?
- Not familiar
 - Familiar
 - Somewhat familiar
 - Very familiar
12. Do you agree that multiculturalism & multilingualism of India needs to be encouraged even in English classroom?

- Strongly agree
- Agree
- Neutral
- Disagree
- Strongly disagree

13. For English language teaching/learning in India, do you think the inclusion of indigenous cultural texts, traditions, and folktales will make it more enjoyable and easy to learn? Give your views on it.

14. Do you think that bridging the gap between the culture of English and the native language is essential for better understanding of both English and our culture? Explain your views on the issue.

FEEDBACK

How was your experience while filling this Questionnaire?

- Extremely Difficult
- Somewhat Difficult
- Neutral
- Somewhat Easy
- Extremely Easy

Elaborate your Experience

8.2 Annexure 2: Questionnaire (Teachers)

Description

The aim of this research is to investigate how teaching English in Higher Education can be more engaging and culturally grounded. The following questionnaire will require approximately 5-7 minutes to complete. Thank you for taking your time in helping us with this research. Under no circumstances are you obliged to answer any of the questions, however, in doing so will greatly assist us in completing our research and enhancing the understanding of this research focus. The data collected will remain confidential and used solely for academic purposes.

SECTION – A

(General information)

1) Your Mother tongue/home language(s):

2) Other language(s) you know besides your home language(s) (rank them in order of your proficiency):

3) What subject(s)/ Paper(s) do you teach at present?

4) Across the following domains, what language do you prefer to speak?

Family _____

College _____

Friend's _____

Marketplace _____

5) What language(s) besides English do you use while teaching in the class? (Put in order of the degree of use)

a).....

b).....

c).....

6) What language(s) do your students use besides English to communicate with you in the class? _____

7) What language(s) do your students use besides English to communicate with you outside the class? _____

8) What problems do you think non-Hindi/non-English speaking children face in your classroom?

SECTION - B

(Introducing Problem)

9) Have you ever been in a situation where you had difficulty in conveying your message to the students with different language backgrounds?

a) Yes

b) No

c) Sometimes

What steps have you taken to address their needs?

10) Do you encourage students to share their lived experience in the classroom and does it help to break the communication barrier?

a) Yes

b) No

10.1) If yes, what steps have you taken to encourage them to share their lived experiences in the classroom. Can you share some experiences with us?

11) Do you think that use of the learner's language and cultural references in the class is necessary at the university level too?

a) Yes

b) No

11.1) what should be done at the university level to promote the use of learner's cultural references and language?

12) What do you think about the use of a monolingual teaching method against the multilingual teaching method?

13) Do you think that multilingual/multicultural text can be used in the classroom?

a) Yes

b) No

14) While teaching English, do you find the students disinterested in Eurocentric texts?

15) Do you think English not being the native language poses difficulty for students in communicating their ideas freely?

a) Yes

b) No

c) Sometimes

SECTION – C (Solutions and suggestions)

16) How do you feel about teaching and promoting Indian literature and culture through the English language?

17) What is your experience while teaching student's texts related to their culture? And how do the students respond to it?

18) Do you think the recommendation of NEP 2020 which suggests inclusion of Indian culture and value system can help students feel connected and attentive toward the English language?

19) Will the inclusion of text rooted in Indian culture in the English curriculum can change the student behaviour, interest and participation in the English class?

8.3 Annexure 3: Questionnaire (Students Profile)

1. Name:

2. Course:

3. Subject Combination:

4. Mother Tongue:

5. Place of Birth:

6. Place of Primary Schooling (if different from Place of Birth) & Medium of Instruction:

7. Place of Secondary Schooling (if different from Place of Birth) & Medium of Instruction:

8. Place of Higher Secondary Schooling (if different from Place of Birth) & Medium of Instruction:

9. Number of Languages Known:
10. Languages that you can Understand, Speak & Write:
11. Languages that you can read & write:
12. Languages that you can speak (conversationally) only:
13. Languages that you can understand only:
14. Which group do you belong to and the topic of your presentation?
15. Give your feedback on the topic of the presentation

8.4 Annexure 4: Bio notes of Researchers (students)

Shubham Dhyani

He is a student of BCom Programme II Year. He belongs to Uttarakhand and his mother tongue is Gadwali. Apart from it he also speaks Hindi, English. He has a passive understanding of all the major Indo Aryan languages. He is also learning Japanese. He has an interest in Indian culture and feels that it should be widely promoted within the Indian education system. He decided to join this project as it is related to promoting Indian culture and language in English Language Teaching.

Aditi Yadav

She is pursuing a Bachelor of Arts in History and Economics. She belongs to New Delhi and her mother tongue is Hindi. She also speaks Hindi, English and Punjabi. She has a passive understanding of Haryanvi and Pashto. Currently, she is learning German. Other than learning languages she has keen interest in understanding communication barriers, discussing and debating new topics which is why she is a part of Debating Society therefore, her purpose in joining this project is to learn more about learning a language and how cultural differences can affect it.

Aashish Kumar

He is a student of B.A Programme (Eco + Pol Science) II year. He belongs to Nalanda, Bihar. His mother tongue is Magahi. Apart from it he also speaks Hindi & English. He is interested in debates and discussion. He has been an integral member of the Debating Society of the college. He also has interest in indigenous literature and diverse cultures of India. He decided to work in this project as it offers him to study about indigenous literature and incorporation Indian culture in English Language Teaching.

Mukul Yadav

He is pursuing BCom Programme (II year). He belongs to Gurugram, Haryana. His mother tongue is Ahirwati, He also speaks Hindi, English, Haryanvi. He is at present also pursuing for certification in Japanese language, along with learning PYTHON programming language. He has keen interest in decolonisation and genocide studies along with reading about ancient historical accounts. He became a part of this project to learn the views and difficulties of students regarding English language and how indigenizing the English language can promote rich heritage and culture of diversified Indian people and how the process of English learning can be made easier through it.

Arya Kumar

He is a student of B.A Programme (Eco + Pol Science) I year. He belongs to Nabinagar, Bihar. His mother tongue is Magahi. Apart from this he also speaks Hindi, English and Bhojpuri. He has a passive understanding of Marathi, Panjabi and Gujarati. He has a keen interest in understanding and exploring the diverse cultures of India and works of literature written around it.

Shubhika Garg

She is pursuing BCom Programme (III year). She knows Hindi, English and Punjabi language. Her areas of interest include literature, literary and culture theory and Indian Literature in English. She is interested in photography, creative writing to express her ideas through it.

Pranshit P. Kishnani

He is a student of BA Programme II year (Political Science and Geography). His mother tongue is Hindi. He also knows English, Marwari, Sindhi and Rajasthani. His primary interest in geography, led to interest in research and methodology and trying to find out things via survey.

Aryan Kumar Raj

He is pursuing BCom Programme (III year). He worked as a 'Student Editor' for the Website Management Committee, SBSEC and also designed the Prospectus of the college. He took active participation in many college activities and acted as the 'Executive Editor' for PRABUDDHA, the annual magazine of the Commerce Department. His area of interest lies in Insurance, and he loves to explore various genres of literature as a hobby.

Vinit Vinayak

He is pursuing a BA Programme (History and Geography) II year. He belongs to New Delhi and his mother tongue is Hindi. He also speaks Hindi, English and Kannada. He has a passive understanding of Bhojpuri, Tamil and Marathi. He also has an interest in literature.

Lovyansh Goyal

He is a student of BCom Programme I Year. He is from Ludhiana; Punjab and his mother tongue is Punjabi. He also knows Hindi, English and Haryanvi.

Applied research

**Socio-Cultural Assimilation: Integrating
Multiculturalism and Multilingualism in English
Classes at College Level**

Project ID

RICGP/0021/SBSE/2021

**IF YOU WOULD LIKE TO GIVE ANY FEEDBACK TO THE
RESEARCH TEAM, YOU CAN MAIL IT TO US AT:**

project0021@sbse.du.ac.in

**THANK YOU FOR TAKING OUT TIME TO READ OUR
RESEARCH**